

Piano & Lecture

Rachmaninoff and the Orthodox Bells

Matfei Sadakatsu Tsuchida

— PROGRAM —

- Prelude in C# minor "The Bells", Op. 3-2
- Six Moments Musicaux, Op. 16
- Piano Sonata No. 2 in Bb minor, Op. 36
- Études-Tableaux, Op. 39-9 in D major

Rachmaninoff was a devout Orthodox Christian. In his creations, yearning for the eternal God, compassion and sorrow for the world, the resulting anguish, and boundless joy resound.

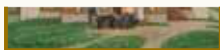
Pianist Matfei Sadakatsu Tsuchida, who loves Rachmaninoff and lives the Orthodox faith, recites and performs a poem of love and life's joy.

Venue: Osaka Orthodox Church
5 min walk from Hankyu Toyotsu Stn / 15 min from JR
Suita Stn

Tuesday, February 23, 2027 (National Holiday)
2:00 PM Start (Doors open at 1:30 PM)

Contribution: ¥1,500 (Open Seating · Limited to 100 Seats)

Reservations Open: December 1, 2026



Matfei Sadakatsu Tsuchida — Biography

Born in Tokyo in 1975. After completing the Soloist Diploma Course at Toho Gakuen School of Music, he studied in Russia, graduating from the Moscow Conservatory and completing postgraduate studies. Studied under Yukiko Konishi, Harumi Sakata, Masako Kanematsu, A. Mndoyants, and V. Merzhanov.

In 2002, awarded 1st Prize at the 3rd International Rachmaninoff Piano Competition. Has performed extensively across Russia, Ukraine, Croatia, Thailand, South Korea, Hong Kong, and throughout Japan (Tokyo Bunka Kaikan, Tokyo Opera City, Casals Hall, Sumida Triphony Hall, Yokohama Minato Mirai, Nerima Culture Center, Miyagi Prefectural Auditorium).

Performed with major orchestras including the Tchaikovsky Symphony Orchestra under V. Fedoseyev, HRT Croatian Radio Symphony under B. Tavrić, and Tokyo Philharmonic conducted by Keiko Mitsuhashi.

CD Releases: 'Rachmaninoff: 24 Preludes', 'Piano Masterpieces: Overcoming'. Books: 'Play Rachmaninoff' (Russian edition 2016), 'The Essence of Rachmaninoff Performance' (2023). Recipient of honor certificates from the Mayor of Perm (2016), Gunsan Police Station (2016), and President L. Kuchma of Ukraine (2016).

Currently Professor at Shokei Gakuin University, Lecturer at Miyagi Gakuin Women's University, faithful member and choir conductor at Sendai Orthodox Church.

About Orthodox Church Bells

In Orthodox tradition, bells hold a sacred place. Tokyo's Holy Resurrection Cathedral (Nikolai-do) has been renowned since pre-war times for 'The Bells of Nikolai', inspiring songs and poetry. In Hakodate, the Orthodox church has long been affectionately called 'Gangan-ji' (the Bell-Ringing Temple).

Bells announce divine services, mark the arrival of hierarchs, mourn the falling asleep of the faithful, and alert during floods or fires. More deeply, their sacred chime is believed to convey God's grace, dispelling demonic temptations and filling the faithful with courage and spiritual peace.

Orthodox belfries feature sets of tuned bells: Nikolai-do has 16, while Hakodate and Osaka each have 6, connected by ropes and rung rhythmically by dedicated bell-ringers in breathing harmony.

The slow, deep stroke of the largest bell is called in Russian 'Blagovest'—meaning 'Good Tidings' or 'The Gospel'. The bell-ringer holds an office akin to clergy: before ringing, they receive the priest's blessing, make the Sign of the Cross before icons cast on the bell, and bow in reverence.

Bells are cast from copper and tin, enriched with silver and gold. In imperial Russia, crowds gathered at the furnace as prayers were chanted, offering gold and silver coins into the molten bronze. Tarkovsky famously immortalized this sacred art in his cinematic masterpiece, 'Andrei Rublev'.

For Orthodox Christians, church bells are life itself—a loving call from God and a voice of heavenly joy.

Listen to the Bells
Scan QR Codes



1904: Nikolai-do Belfry. Ringing in traditional kimono and zori sandals. (Tokyo Resurrection Cathedral Album)



Nikolai-do Bells



Osaka Church Bells



1910: Great Bell gifted from Russia with 4 relief icons. Damaged in 1945 air raid; now resting by church. (Osaka Church)